even before the communists had come to power, Indian decision-makers were aware that they would have a problem with China. As early as 1948, the new Indian ambassador in China, the historian and geopolitical thinker K.M. Panikkar, had written warningly to Delhi. He noted that as the successor state to British India, independent India had inherited rights in Tibet. It should expect the new Chinese government to fully integrate Tibet, and in doing so challenge the validity of the McMahon Line in the eastern sector.[2]

Shortly after the communists took power, Girja Shankar Bajpai, Secretary General in the Ministry of External Affairs, had a more general worry about China, namely, its communism and strategic views. He confided to the British High Commission in Delhi that 'Chinese Communists, like any other Communists, reacted well to firmness but would exploit any sign of weakness'. In a letter to Nehru's sister Vijaya Lakshmi Pandit, he noted he was trying to curb the prime minister's 'enthusiasm' over China. In October 1950, British diplomats reported Bajpai to have said that with the end of the civil war in China, India would have a 'militaristic and aggressive nation' on its borders – in other words, a greedy country.[3]

Unable, he felt, to curb Nehru's enthusiasm, Bajpai penned a long note on relations with China. He sent the note to – in his view – the more hard-headed deputy prime minister, Sardar Patel, on 31 October 1950. With some amendments, Patel transmitted the letter under his own signature to Nehru. This is the now-famous 7 November 1950 letter on China policy. In it Bajpai/Patel underlined the concern that China would have a military and political presence right up to India's borderlands and to the small, vulnerable Himalayan states of Nepal, Sikkim, and Bhutan as well as Burma. Given the difficulties with Pakistan over Kashmir, India would face a two-front challenge. This necessitated both internal and external security reforms and a review of India's diplomacy with the Anglo-American powers and China. Patel died soon after sending the letter to Nehru and never got a reply. While Bajpai and Patel did not quite urge immediate